

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

THE CHALLENGES

20 THOUSAND
Estimated no. of commercial units to be rehabilitated

₹8,623 CRORE
Estimated annual turnover of informal economy in Dharavi



"Eligible slum dwellers will be rehabilitated in Dharavi itself. The industries and businesses will get space too. Dharavi is not just an area where people stay, it's an economic hub"

—DEVENDRA FADNAVIS, *Maharashtra CM*

A CITY WITHIN A CITY

Dharavi has always been a magnet for economic migrants from across the country, who reclaimed the swamplands to build huts and small businesses, marking the foundations of Mumbai's oldest slum. Informal businesses flourished even during the stormy 1970s and '80s, when the area was the stomping ground of criminals like the late underworld don Varadarajan Mudaliar. But since the '90s, Dharavi has grown into an informal economic hub, with an estimated annual turnover of $1 billion (Rs 8,623 crore). Its manufacturing, retail and commercial units and single-room factories, which span a massive 627,292 sq. m. in built-up area, make everything from garments, wigs, pots, diyas to leather goods. Kiran Dighavkar, deputy municipal commissioner, Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC), says Dharavi is driven by the instinct of commerce. "Dharavi is the Malabar Hill of slums. There is only one religion and caste in Dharavi—money," says the bureaucrat.

S.V.R. Srinivas, CEO of DRP, which is in charge of the redevelopment, says the makeover is a *sui generis* case—virtually without precedent. "Dharavi is different in every sense, compared to conventional Slum Redevelopment Authority (SRA) projects," says the IAS officer. "We are building a city within a city, not just a few buildings...this is the brownest of the brownfield projects, the world's largest urban renewal project." The redevelopment is envisaged as a phased 'key-to-key venture', which minimises the need to shift residents into transit accommodation, and instead helps them move directly into permanent homes.

For residents like Swami, the offer is alluring: a free home with running water and two toilets will be a world apart from his current under-the-bed existence. For Adani, the potential upside is massive. The Dharavi revamp project could see prime real estate being unlocked in the heart of Mumbai, a Rs 2.5 lakh crore transformation that could reshape the city's skyline and cement his image as a national infrastructure builder par excellence. Group chairman Gautam Adani emphasises that it is not all about money. "Our Dharavi Social Mission," he says, "will uplift the youth through skilling, healthcare and employment programmes. Over 1 million people will move from narrow lanes to a township that features spacious layouts, dual toilets, schools, hospitals, transit hubs and parks."

At the same time, the risks are equally monumental for Adani. The businessman is staking his reputation on one of the most complex urban transformation projects in the world. Dharavi is not a single slum, but a dense, pulsating ecosystem of informal housing, micro industries, migrant communities and deep-rooted social networks built over decades. Any hint of insensitivity or bulldozing without consensus could trigger a backlash far beyond Dharavi. Realty consultant Prashant Thakur, regional director and head-research and advisory, Anarock Property Consultants Pvt. Ltd, says the massive logistical and social tasks involved in